



The Brother Outside the Door

The Tyler

RESPONSIBILITIES

The oldest office in the lodge and the only one historically paid. Why he sits outside, what he is actually guarding against, and why the last toast of the night belongs to him.

ON THE TABLE

The Tyler's sword, and his chair outside the door

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:00	The word
2:30	The oldest office, and the paid one
4:00	What he is actually guarding against
6:00	The sword
7:30	His other duty
8:45	Closing: the last toast

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 To *tyle* is to roof — to make a place covered, so what happens inside is not visible outside.
- 2 A cowan is not a stranger. He is a man who does something that looks like the work without having earned it.
- 3 The Tyler sees none of the ceremony, and is given the last toast of the night — for the brethren who are not there.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

Is the Tyler always a member of the lodge?

Not necessarily, and historically often not. Many towns had a Tyler who served several lodges for a fee.

Why a sword and not something else?

Practical origin — an armed man on a stair. It survives as the emblem of the office.

What exactly is a cowan?

A Scots operative term for an untrained man who built without mortar. It means a pretender to the craft, not merely a stranger.

Is the Tyler still paid?

In some lodges, yes — a small honorarium is still common and entirely traditional.

SOURCES

- Emulation Ritual, published by Lewis Masonic — the opening and the duties of the office
- Anderson, The Constitutions of the Free-Masons, 1723
- Knoop & Jones, The Genesis of Freemasonry (1947) — on cowans and operative practice
- Harry Carr, The Freemason at Work — the standard answer book on questions of this kind
- Your own lodge's nineteenth-century accounts, for the Tyler's fee

Every paper is drawn from openly published masonic literature. Nothing here discloses the esoteric work of any degree; all of it is safe to deliver with visitors present, provided the visitors are brethren.

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